
Transgenerational Trauma

What truly passes from one generation to the next

4 psychology approaches · by EvaTalk

TO BEGIN

What truly passes from one generation to the next

We hear that trauma is 'passed down' in families. It's true — but mainly through how it shapes parenting, attachment, silences and the family climate. The idea of a purely 'biological' transmission is still being researched.

This guide helps you understand what truly transmits, and see that it isn't a fate.

YOUR INTENTION

A pattern or fear that seems to 'come from far back' in your family: _____

The relational route, the best established

What's solidly demonstrated is relational transmission: a parent marked by trauma often (unintentionally) passes on fears, silences, attachment styles and ways of reacting. The child learns these patterns through example and family atmosphere.

Biological (epigenetic) transmission is a promising but unsettled research avenue in humans — the safest route to understand remains relational.

Example

Léa had 'inherited' her mother's anxiety; understanding she had learned it, not biologically suffered it, gave her power back.

My transmission

Which pattern might you have learned by example, in your family?

Learned, so changeable

Write: 'What is learned can also be transformed.'

Takeaway — The best-established transmission is relational — therefore changeable.

'I'm doomed to repeat'

'It's in my family, I won't escape it', 'I'll repeat the same story', 'it's genetic, nothing I can do': these thoughts turn a legacy into a fate.

Reframe them: transmission isn't a sentence.

Example

'In my family, we all end up this way' trapped Sami, until he saw awareness already changed things.

Spot the fate

Note a thought making your legacy a fate · a fairer version.

Not a fate

Write: 'A legacy isn't a fate.'

Takeaway — Transmission isn't a fate: becoming aware already loosens it.

Honor your lineage AND write your page

You can acknowledge what your ancestors lived — their courage, their wounds — without being obliged to carry the weight in their place. Honoring your lineage and choosing your own path don't conflict.

You're the link who can transform the story, not only prolong it.

Example

By honoring her grandparents' story while allowing herself another path, Nia found peace.

My page

What do you want to keep from your legacy, and what to transform?

The transforming link

Write: 'I honor my lineage and write my own page.'

Takeaway — You can honor your lineage while writing your own story.

See the family patterns

In practice: observe the patterns that repeat (roles, fears, silences, ways of loving or fleeing) across generations. Naming them — for instance with a small genogram — strips away part of their automatic power. And professional support helps untangle what's stubborn.

What we bring to light stops acting in the shadows.

Example

By drawing his family's repeated patterns, Karim clearly saw what he could choose to stop.

My pattern

A pattern that repeats across generations: _____

Name it

Write: 'What I bring to light stops acting in the shadows.'

Takeaway — Spot and name family patterns: it's the start of change.

Key takeaways

- The best-established transmission is relational — therefore changeable.
- The biological/epigenetic part in humans is still being researched.
- A legacy isn't a fate: awareness already loosens it.
- You can honor your lineage AND write your own page.
- Spot the patterns that repeat (roles, fears, silences).
- Naming them (e.g. a genogram) strips their automatic power.

Your turn

My legacy

The learned pattern	The fate thought

My transformation

Keep / transform	My repeated pattern

YOUR JOURNEY

Your 4-week plan

Week 1

Understand the relational route of transmission.

Week 2

Reframe 'I'm doomed to repeat'.

Week 3

Honor my lineage and choose my path.

Week 4

Spot and name my family patterns.

YOUR PLAN

Your action plan

My 'a legacy isn't a fate' line:

What I want to transform:

My repeated pattern to name:

You aren't doomed to repeat — you can be the one who transforms.

This guide is a psychoeducation tool, not therapy or a diagnosis. It distinguishes what is established (the relational transmission of trauma) from what is still being researched (biological and epigenetic mechanisms in humans). If you carry trauma, professional support (a psychologist or psychotherapist) is a precious help. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.